

REQUEST FOR INFORMATION (RFI)

**AIR FORCE RESEARCH LABORATORY
CENTER FOR RAPID INNOVATION (AFRL/RSC)**

AUTOMATED COUNTER-UAS EXPEDITIONARY SOLUTIONS (ACES)

1. NOTICE

This Request for Information (RFI) is issued for informational purposes only and does not constitute a solicitation or commit the government to award a contract now or in the future, as defined in RFO FAR 15.101(c). This RFI is not a request for proposals; therefore, responses to this RFI are not considered offers and cannot be accepted by the Government to form a binding contract. The Government does not intend to award a contract on the basis of this RFI or otherwise pay for the information requested. Responses will be treated as information only and not as a proposal.

Submitting information for this RFI is voluntary, and participants will not be compensated. RFI respondents will have no competitive advantage in receiving any awards related to the technical/capability area of Automated Counter-UAS. The information submitted in response to this RFI may be used to help the Government further define its requirements. If the Government develops a program that addresses any submitted or similar topic, the resulting procurement will address technology and business specific requirements as defined by the Government to achieve the required objectives.

2. BACKGROUND AND SCOPE

The proliferation of small, low-cost Unmanned Aerial Systems (UAS) poses a significant and growing threat to military and civilian assets. These systems can be used for adversarial intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) or as direct-attack weapon platforms. A critical need exists for a point-defense capability that can be deployed rapidly and affordably to protect fixed and semi-fixed sites, such as airbases, forward operating bases, and critical infrastructure.

Current solutions are often expensive, require significant operator training and supervision, or lack the automation and speed needed to counter multiple, simultaneous, or swarming threats effectively. This RFI seeks to identify potential industry and academic partners with mature or rapidly maturing solutions for a low-cost, rapidly fieldable, and fully automated end-to-end Counter-UAS (C-UAS) system. The Government is interested in solutions capable of performing the full "detect-to-defeat" sequence with minimal human intervention.

3. CAPABILITY GAP

The primary operational challenge is to provide robust, 24/7 point-defense against individual and swarming Group 1 and 2 UAS threats (as defined by the Department of War). The desired

solution must be capable of operating in complex electromagnetic and physical (clutter) environments with a high density of friendly, neutral, and hostile UAS.

The key capability gaps to be addressed are:

- 1) Automation: The end-to-end engagement cycle - from initial detection to confirmed defeat - must be executed in seconds. A high degree of automation is required to reduce operator burden and enable the system to react faster than a human operator.
- 2) Affordability: The system must perform at a very low cost-per-engagement method to affordably counter the threat posed by inexpensive, commercially available UAS. The overall system procurement cost must also be low enough to allow for wide-scale fielding.
- 3) Rapid Fielding: The system must be simple to transport, set up, and operate, allowing for rapid deployment to austere locations with minimal personnel and logistical support.

4. DESIRED SYSTEM ATTRIBUTES

The Government is interested in information on integrated systems, subsystems, or novel technologies that address the following attributes:

- Automated End-to-End Kill Chain: A fully integrated system that automates the detect, track, identify, prioritize, and defeat sequence with options for man-in-the-loop supervision and flexible rules of engagement.
- Multi-Modal Sensing: A robust sensor suite (e.g., Electro-Optical/Infrared (EO/IR), Radio Frequency (RF) detection, acoustic, small-form-factor radar) capable of detecting, tracking, and identifying low-signature UAS in various weather and environmental conditions.
- Automated Command and Control (C2): Software that fuses all sensor data, uses advanced algorithms (including AI/ML) for classification and identification, assesses hostile intent, and executes engagements automatically based on pre-defined criteria.
- Low-Cost Defeat Mechanism: An effector that has a low cost-per-shot and is effective against Group 1 and 2 UAS. Both kinetic (e.g., guided projectiles, fragmentation) and non-kinetic (e.g., High-Power Microwave, focused Electronic Attack) solutions are of interest.
- Rapid Deployment & Usability: A system with a small physical and logistical footprint that is easily transportable, can be set up and operational in under one hour by a small team (1-2 personnel), and features a simple user interface.

- Open System Architecture: Use of non-proprietary interfaces (such as the C-UAS System Integration (CSI) standard) to allow for the rapid integration of new sensors, effectors, or C2 software from third parties.

5. INSTRUCTIONS TO POTENTIAL RESPONDENTS

Interested parties who desire to participate in this RFI are encouraged to submit responses that clearly demonstrate an ability to meet the stated requirements, or a portion of the requirements.

Responses shall include the following information on the title page and address the general requirements as delineated in paragraph 6:

- a. Company/Institute Name:
- b. Address:
- c. Point of Contact (to include phone number and email address):
- d. CAGE Code:
- e. Web Page URL:
- f. Size of business pursuant to NAICS Code 541715.
- g. State whether the company is domestically or foreign owned (if foreign, please indicate the country of ownership).
- h. State whether the respondents are interested in being a prime or subcontractor for this requirement.
- i. Indicate whether the company is currently performing this type of work/whether the capability can be obtained under an existing Government contract. Provide the contract number(s) and Government points of contact accordingly.

6. GENERAL REQUIREMENTS

- a. Company/Capability Overview: Provide a brief description of your company's core competencies and experience in developing and fielding C-UAS technologies, automated systems, sensors, or effectors.
- b. Technical Approach: Describe your proposed system or subsystem architecture. Detail your approach for:
 - i. Detection, tracking, and positive identification.
 - ii. Command and Control (C2), including the level of automation and use of AI/ML.
 - iii. The defeat mechanism(s).
- c. System Performance:
 - i. What is the estimated detection and engagement range for a typical Group 1 UAS (e.g., DJI Phantom-sized)?
 - ii. What is the estimated end-to-end timeline, from initial detection to defeat?

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- iii. Describe the system's ability to handle multiple targets or swarms. What is the system's "shot capacity" or time-to-recharge?
- d. Maturity and Readiness:
 - i. What is the current Technology Readiness Level (TRL) of your proposed system and its key subsystems?
 - ii. Describe any testing, demonstrations, or operational deployments conducted to date. Include performance data if available.
- e. Cost and Affordability:
 - i. Provide a Rough Order of Magnitude (ROM) cost for a single complete prototype system.
 - ii. Provide a ROM cost for production units at quantities of 10, 50, and 100 units.
 - iii. Provide an estimated cost-per-engagement for your defeat mechanism.
- f. Fielding & Logistics:
 - i. Describe the Size, Weight, Power, and Cooling (SWaP-C) requirements of the complete system.
 - ii. Outline the typical steps, timeline, and personnel required for system setup and teardown.
 - iii. Describe the required operator and maintainer skill level and training.

7. RESPONSE REQUIREMENTS:

- a. Responses to this RFI are limited to 6 pages with one-inch margins using standard letter-size 8 1/2" x 11" pages. The page count includes any title page. Font for text must be Calibri 10-point or larger, single sided. Responses should include technical and descriptive text to provide sufficient detail on how they would satisfy the requirements outlined in paragraph 6.

The submitted documentation becomes the property of the U.S. Government and will not be returned.

- b. Responses are limited to one (1) per company. Marketing information is NOT acceptable in the response. Endorsements from elected officials at the federal, state and/or local levels are NOT acceptable in the response.
- c. Respondents who submit proprietary data shall clearly mark the data with appropriate markings on the cover sheet and on each applicable page. Any proprietary data submitted may be handled by contract support services personnel who have signed Non-Disclosure Agreements (NDA). Any proprietary information received in response to this request will be properly protected from any unauthorized disclosure. The Government will not use proprietary information submitted from any one firm to establish the capability and requirements for any future systems acquisition, so as to not inadvertently restrict competition. Any material that is not marked proprietary will be considered publicly releasable.

8. COMMUNICATION AND ADDITIONAL CONSIDERATIONS:

- a. The government may contact respondents to obtain additional information or clarification in order to fully understand a company's response.
- b. The Government does not intend to award a contract on the basis of this RFI or otherwise pay for the information requested. Responses will be treated as information only and not as a proposal. Companies will not be paid for the information submitted.
- c. Broad industry participation for this Sources Sought is encouraged. U.S. and non-U.S. firms are permitted to respond to this SSS/RFI.
- d. This notice may be updated as additional information becomes available. Please check the Sam.gov site for updates to this announcement and register to receive e-mail notices of any updates to the Sam.gov announcement. For more information on this RFI, please contact the AFRL POCs below via email.
- e. Please note that all prospective contractors must be registered in System for Award Management (SAM) database to be awarded a Department of Defense contract. To learn more about this SAM requirement and how to register, please visit the SAM internet website at <https://sam.gov/>

9. SUBMISSION OF DOCUMENTATION:

- a. Responses to the RFI shall be submitted to the points of contacts below by 4:00 PM Eastern Time, 07 April 2026.
- b. Please submit all responses to the below POCs:

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